

```
VBOX_MSI_INSTALL_PATH=C:\Program Files\Oracle\VirtualBox\  
windir=C:\WINDOWS
```

The text on the left side of the equal sign (=) is the environment variable name, and the text on the right side is the string value. Every process has its own set of environment variables, so different command lines can have different values for their environment variables.

You can also view the value of a single environment variable with the `echo` command. Run `echo %HOMEPATH%` on Windows or `echo $HOME` on macOS and Linux to view the value of the `HOMEPATH` or `HOME` environment variables, respectively, which contain the current user's home folder. On Windows, it looks like this:

```
C:\Users\Al>echo %HOMEPATH%  
\Users\Al
```

On macOS or Linux, it looks like this:

```
al@al-VirtualBox:~$ echo $HOME  
/home/al
```

If that process creates another process (such as when a command line runs the Python interpreter), that child process receives its own copy of the parent process's environment variables. The child process can change the values of its environment variables without affecting the parent process's environment variables, and vice versa.

You can think of the operating system's set of environment variables as the "master copy" from which a process copies its environment variables. The operating system's environment variables change less frequently than a Python program's. In fact, most users never directly touch their environment variable settings.

Working with the PATH Environment Variable

When you enter a command, like `python` on Windows or `python3` on macOS and Linux, the terminal checks for a program with that name in the folder